

A GOTHIC HORROR ONE-SHOT

THE ASHEN REQUIEM

A D&D 5e Gothic Horror One-Shot for Levels 3-5

TUCO ENTERPRISES



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ADVENTURE SUMMARY

The village of Ashwick gathers for the funeral of Lord Edmund Ashworth — beloved noble, philanthropist, and patriarch of the Ashworth estate. But when the church bells begin to ring themselves at midnight, the dead rise from their graves, and a ghostly bride emerges from the crypt beneath the church, the party must uncover a decades-old tragedy before the village is consumed by vengeful spirits.

This is a **self-contained one-shot** designed for 3–4 hours of play. It can be completed in a single session or split across two shorter sessions. The adventure features investigation, social encounters, and a climactic battle in the crypt beneath St. Agatha's Church.

ADVENTURE DETAILS

System	D&D 5e
Levels	3–5
Players	3–5
Sessions	1 (3–4 hours)
Tone	Gothic horror mystery
Themes	Death, betrayal, vengeance

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

Core Rules	D&D 5e (SRD)
Handouts	Blood-stained letter (P15)
Maps	Village + Floor plan
Music	Organ, ambient horror
Prep Time	15 minutes

ADVENTURE HOOK: THE INVITATION

"The letter arrives on black-edged parchment, sealed with wax bearing a raven clutching a rose. 'You are cordially invited to the funeral of Lord Edmund Ashworth, beloved patriarch of Ashwick, who departed this world on the 14th of Harvestmere. Your presence is requested at St. Agatha's Church at sunset. Refreshments will be served at Ashworth Hall following the service. — Lady Cordelia Ashworth, Mistress of Ashworth Hall.'"

The party may have any connection to Ashwick — former visitors, hired escorts, distant relatives, or simply travelers passing through. Lady Cordelia has sent invitations widely, hoping to fill the church for her father's funeral. The adventure begins as the party arrives at the village at dusk.

DM NOTE

This adventure works best with atmospheric lighting and organ music. Read all "read-aloud" text slowly and dramatically. The horror builds gradually — start with unease, escalate to dread, and climax with terror. Let the players' investigation drive the pacing.

ASHWICK VILLAGE

A quiet village in mourning

DANGER ●○○○○

ARRIVAL

"The village of Ashwick lies in a shallow valley, surrounded by ancient oaks and fog. Smoke curls from cottage chimneys. A stone church with a tall spire rises above the rooftops. Every window in the village glows with candlelight — even the empty cottages. Black crepe hangs from every door. The air smells of damp earth and funeral lilies."

Ashwick is a village of approximately 300 souls. The economy revolves around the Ashworth estate — most villagers work the land or serve the manor. Since Lord Edmund's death two weeks ago, the village has been in deep mourning. Strangers are noted but not unwelcome — Lady Cordelia has invited many guests for the funeral.

KEY LOCATIONS

- ◆ **St. Agatha's Church:** Stone church at the village center. The funeral service will be held here. Beneath the church: a crypt containing the Ashworth family tombs. *This is the adventure's climactic location.*
- ◆ **Ashworth Hall:** Grand Victorian manor on the hill overlooking the village. Lady Cordelia's residence. Refreshments after the funeral. The manor is normally off-limits but open for the wake.
- ◆ **The Drowned Crow (Inn):** Village inn. Run by a widow named Hilda Marsh. Rooms 4sp/night. The inn is full of funeral guests — the party may need to share rooms or sleep in the stable.
- ◆ **Village Green:** Central gathering place. A dried-up stone fountain stands in the center. Villagers gather here to gossip. The party can learn local rumors here.
- ◆ **The Graveyard:** Behind the church. Ancient headstones, some dating back centuries. The Ashworth family plot is in the northeast corner, marked by a stone mausoleum.

VILLAGE RUMORS (DC 12 CHARISMA CHECK OR 10 MINUTES OF CONVERSATION)

D6	RUMOR
1	"Lord Edmund didn't die of natural causes. He was found in the crypt at midnight, cold as stone, with a look of terror on his face."
2	"Lady Cordelia has been acting strange since the funeral was announced. She's been visiting the crypt every night alone."
3	"Father Benedict says the bells rang by themselves three nights running. He's been praying over the graves since."
4	"Old Silas the groundskeeper says he's seen a woman in white walking the graveyard at night. He thinks it's Eleanor — Lord Edmund's first wife, the one they don't talk about."
5	"There's a letter. A blood-stained letter found in Lord Edmund's study. Lady Cordelia burned it, but Hilda at the inn saw it first. Something about a wedding that never happened."
6	"The crypt hasn't been opened in twenty years. Not since Eleanor Ashworth was buried. They say Lord Edmund couldn't bear to look at her grave."

MAP: ASHWICK VILLAGE

Key locations and points of interest



Ashwick — A small gothic village surrounded by ancient oaks and fog. The church and graveyard dominate the center; Ashworth Hall watches from the hill above.

KEY LOCATIONS

- ◆ **A — St. Agatha's Church:** The funeral service. Crypt entrance is through a door behind the altar (locked, DC 14 Thieves' Tools, or key from Father Benedict).
- ◆ **B — The Graveyard:** Ancient burial ground. The Ashworth mausoleum is in the northeast corner. Eleanor's grave is marked by a simple stone with no name — only a date: 12th of Frostfall, 1247.
- ◆ **C — Ashworth Hall:** The manor house on the hill. Open for the wake after the funeral. Lady Cordelia's private chambers are on the upper floor.
- ◆ **D — The Drowned Crow (Inn):** Rooms, rumors, and warm meals. Hilda Marsh can share what she saw in Lord Edmund's study.
- ◆ **E — Village Green:** Central gathering place. Dried fountain. Villagers share rumors here in the evening.
- ◆ **F — Silas's Cottage:** Small cottage at the edge of the graveyard. Silas the groundskeeper lives here. He has a key to the crypt.

THE FUNERAL SERVICE

All of Ashwick gathers to say goodbye

⚠ DANGER ●●○○○



The funeral procession moves through the village at dusk, candles flickering in the fog.

THE PROCESSION

"Six pallbearers carry the polished oak coffin through the village street. Behind them walks Lady Cordelia Ashworth in black mourning dress, her face hidden behind a veil. Father Benedict leads the procession, chanting prayers in a low, resonant voice. The villagers follow in silence, each holding a candle. The only sound is the crunch of footsteps on wet cobblestones and the distant tolling of the church bell."

The procession begins at Ashworth Hall and winds down the hill to St. Agatha's Church. The party can observe or join. During the procession, each character may make a **DC 13 Perception check** — success notices that one of the pallbearers is **Silas the groundskeeper**, and his hands are trembling.

THE SERVICE

Inside the church, Father Benedict delivers a eulogy praising Lord Edmund's generosity and kindness. Lady Cordelia sits in the front pew, silent and still. The service lasts approximately 30 minutes. During the service:

- ◆ **DC 12 Perception:** The church is unusually cold. Breath mists in the air. The candles flicker though there is no draft.
- ◆ **DC 14 Perception:** A faint sound — like a woman crying — seems to come from beneath the church. The crypt.
- ◆ **DC 13 Insight:** Father Benedict's hands shake as he reads from the prayer book. His eyes keep darting to the crypt door behind the altar.
- ◆ **DC 15 Perception:** Lady Cordelia is not crying. Behind her veil, her expression is one of cold calculation, not grief.

AFTER THE SERVICE — THE WAKE AT ASHWORTH HALL

Following the burial, guests are invited to Ashworth Hall for the wake. This is a social encounter opportunity. Key NPCs present:

- ◆ **Lady Cordelia Ashworth:** Grieving daughter. Polite but distant. Can be questioned about her father's death.
- ◆ **Father Benedict:** The village priest. Nervous, evasive. Knows more than he's saying.
- ◆ **Silas the Groundskeeper:** Drinking heavily at the wake. If approached, he's frightened and wants to talk — but not here.

Social Encounter: Each player can attempt one **DC 13 Charisma (Persuasion)** check during the wake to learn one piece of useful information (DM's choice from the rumor table or NPC secrets).

THE WAKE

Secrets and suspicions at Ashworth Hall

LADY CORDELIA ASHWORTH

Cordelia is poised, elegant, and clearly in control of her emotions. She thanks each guest for attending with practiced grace. If questioned about her father's death, she says he "died peacefully in his sleep" — this is a lie (DC 14 Insight to detect).

What Cordelia knows: Her father was found dead in the crypt at midnight, his face frozen in terror. She believes his death was caused by "the curse of Eleanor" — his first wife, who died under mysterious circumstances twenty years ago. Cordelia has been visiting the crypt nightly, trying to "appease" Eleanor's spirit. She doesn't know it yet, but her visits are making things worse.

If confronted about the lie: Cordelia becomes defensive, then breaks down. She admits her father was found in the crypt and she's been terrified something supernatural is happening. She begs the party to investigate.

FATHER BENEDICT

Benedict is drinking wine quickly and avoiding eye contact. If approached privately (DC 12 Persuasion), he admits:

"I've served this village for thirty years. I've never seen anything like this. The bells ring themselves. The crypt door was found open three nights ago — from the inside. And Eleanor's grave... the earth is disturbed. Something is waking down there."

What Benedict knows: He performed Eleanor's funeral twenty years ago. He knows she died on her wedding day — the same day Lord Edmund married her. He suspects foul play but has no proof. He has the key to the crypt but is too frightened to go down alone.

If asked for the key: Benedict will give it to the party if they promise to investigate. He also gives them a **silver holy symbol** blessed by the church (grants +1 to saving throws against undead while held).

SILAS THE GROUNDSKEEPER

Silas is drunk and frightened. If the party approaches him (no check needed — he wants to talk), he pulls them aside:

"I've been digging graves in that cemetery for forty years. I know every stone. And I'm telling you — Eleanor's grave is wrong. The earth is pushed up from below. And I've seen her. A woman in white, standing by the mausoleum at midnight. She doesn't walk — she just... appears."

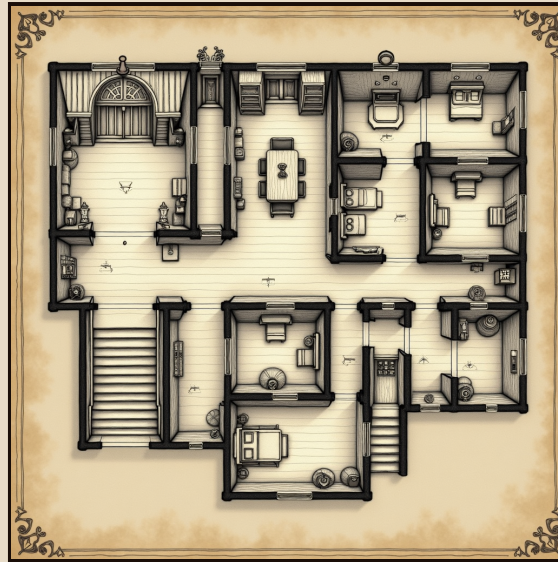
What Silas knows: He saw Lord Edmund enter the crypt the night he died. He heard screaming, but when he went to investigate, the crypt door was locked from the inside. He found Edmund's body the next morning — cold, pale, eyes wide open. Silas also has a key to the crypt.

DM NOTE

The wake is the investigation phase. Let the players choose who to talk to and what to investigate. There is no wrong order. All roads lead to the crypt. If the players don't go to the crypt by midnight, the bells begin to ring and the dead start rising — this is the adventure's "ticking clock."

ASHWORTH HALL

The manor on the hill



Ashworth Hall — Ground floor, upper floor, and basement. The hidden passage in the basement connects to the crypt beneath the church.

KEY ROOMS

- ◆ **Grand Entrance Hall:** Sweeping staircase, chandelier, portraits of Ashworth ancestors. A portrait of Eleanor Ashworth hangs in the gallery — beautiful, pale, in a wedding dress. *DC 13 Investigation: The portrait's eyes seem to follow you.*
- ◆ **Lord Edmund's Study (Upper Floor, Locked DC 14):** Contains his personal papers. A **DC 12 Investigation** check finds a hidden drawer containing a **blood-stained letter** (see Handout, P15) and a journal. The journal reveals Edmund's guilt over Eleanor's death and his belief that "she has come back."
- ◆ **Lady Cordelia's Chambers (Upper Floor, Locked DC 16):** Private quarters. Contains a locket with a miniature portrait of Eleanor and a diary describing Cordelia's nightly visits to the crypt to "beg forgiveness for Father's sins."
- ◆ **Basement — Hidden Passage:** Behind a wine rack (DC 14 Investigation to find), a narrow tunnel leads underground for approximately 200 feet, emerging in the crypt beneath St. Agatha's Church. This is how Lord Edmund accessed the crypt without being seen.

ENCOUNTER: THE MANOR'S SECRET

If the party explores the manor after midnight, they experience supernatural phenomena:

- ◆ The portrait of Eleanor weeps blood (DC 12 WIS save or be frightened for 1 minute)
- ◆ A ghostly wedding march plays from the grand piano in the drawing room — no one is playing it
- ◆ The temperature drops sharply. Frost forms on the windows. A woman's voice whispers: "*He promised me forever. He promised.*"
- ◆ A **Specter** (use Specter stat block) manifests in the gallery, attacking anyone who touches Eleanor's portrait

LADY CORDELIA ASHWORTH

Mistress of Ashworth Hall



Lady Cordelia Ashworth — Beautiful, composed, and hiding a terrible family secret.

LADY CORDELIA ASHWORTH

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), LAWFUL NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	12	11	14	13	16
+0	+1	+0	+2	+2	+3

AC 10 | HP 9 (2d8) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Deception +5, Insight +3, Persuasion +5

Senses: Passive Perception 12

Languages: Common

Personality: Cordelia is poised, intelligent, and deeply conflicted. She loved her father but knows he was guilty of a terrible crime. She's been trying to atone for his sins by visiting Eleanor's grave, but her fear is making her erratic. She will help the party if they promise to put Eleanor's spirit to rest — but she will not admit what her father did unless confronted with proof.

Secret: Cordelia knows the truth about Eleanor's death. Edmund married Eleanor for her family's land, then murdered her on their wedding night by locking her in the crypt and leaving her to die. Cordelia found the truth in her father's journal years ago and has lived with the guilt ever since.

FATHER BENEDICT

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	11	12	13	16	14
+0	+0	+1	+2	+3	+2

AC 10 | HP 18 (2d8+4) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Insight +5, Medicine +5, Religion +4

Spellcasting (Cleric 2): Spell save DC 13, +5 to hit. Cantrips: guidance, sacred flame, thaumaturgy. 1st (3 slots): cure wounds, sanctuary, shield of faith, detect evil and good.

Equipment: Silver holy symbol (+1 vs undead), key to the crypt, prayer book, 5gp

Personality: Benedict is a good man haunted by suspicion. He performed Eleanor's funeral but always believed something was wrong — she was young, healthy, and died suddenly on her wedding day. He wants the truth to come out but is afraid of what it means for the village.

SILAS & THE BRIDE

The groundskeeper and the ghost



Silas — The groundskeeper who knows too much.

SILAS — THE GROUNDSKEEPER

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), CHAOTIC GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14	10	14	11	13	9
+2	+0	+2	+1	+2	-1

AC 11 (leather apron) | HP 22 (3d8+6) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Perception +4, Survival +4, Nature +3

Equipment: Shovel (1d6 bludgeoning), key to the crypt, lantern, flask of whiskey

Personality: Weathered, honest, and terrified. Silas has kept the Ashworth secret for twenty years out of loyalty to the family, but Edmund's death has shaken him. He'll tell the party everything if they promise to stop Eleanor's rampage.

Secret: Silas helped Edmund carry Eleanor's body to the crypt twenty years ago. He didn't know it was murder at the time — Edmund told him she "fell down the stairs." Silas has lived with the guilt ever since.



Eleanor Ashworth — The Bride. Murdered on her wedding day, she has returned for vengeance.

ELEANOR ASHWORTH — THE BRIDE (REVENANT)

MEDIUM UNDEAD, CHAOTIC NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16	14	16	12	14	18
+3	+2	+3	+2	+2	+4

AC 13 (natural armor) | HP 67 (9d8+27) | Speed 30 ft.

Damage Resistances: necrotic, bludgeoning/piercing/slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities: poison | **Condition Immunities:** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, poisoned

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 12

Languages: Common (can't speak, but understands)

Vengeful Tracker. Eleanor knows the direction and distance to Lord Edmund's corpse (in the crypt). If the party has the corpse, she can sense it within 1 mile.

Actions: *Vengeful Slam.* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., 2d8+3 bludgeoning + 1d6 necrotic. *Grave Chill (Recharge 5–6).* 20-ft radius, DC 14 CON save or 3d8 necrotic damage and speed halved (half damage on success).

THE CRYPT BENEATH ST. AGATHA’S

Where the dead do not rest

DANGER ●●●●○

ENTERING THE CRYPT

"The stone stairs descend into darkness. The air is cold and smells of earth and decay. Flickering green light dances on the walls below. The sound of a pipe organ drifts up from the depths — a slow, mournful wedding march played in a minor key."

The crypt is a single large chamber beneath the church. Stone sarcophagi line the walls. In the center, a raised stone altar holds the largest sarcophagus — the Ashworth family tomb. The hidden passage from Ashworth Hall enters from the north wall.

CRYPT FEATURES

- ◆ **Light:** Dim green light emanates from the central sarcophagus. No other light sources unless the party brings them.
- ◆ **Sarcophagi:** Eight stone tombs line the walls. Seven are sealed. One — Eleanor’s — is cracked open from within, the lid pushed aside. Scratch marks are visible on the inside of the lid.
- ◆ **The Altar:** A stone altar in the center of the room. On it: a withered wedding bouquet, a tarnished silver locket, and a blood-stained letter (same as the handout — this is the original).
- ◆ **Lord Edmund’s Body:** Edmund’s corpse lies before the altar, arranged in a funeral pose. His face is frozen in an expression of absolute terror. His hands are clasped over his chest. A wedding ring is on his finger — it wasn’t there when he was found.
- ◆ **The Organ:** A small pipe organ stands against the far wall. It plays by itself — a ghostly wedding march. *DC 14 Arcana check: The organ is being played by Eleanor’s residual magic. Destroying it (AC 10, 15 HP) stops the music but angers Eleanor.*

DISCOVERING THE TRUTH

- The party can piece together what happened by examining the crypt:
- ◆ **DC 12 Investigation (Eleanor’s sarcophagus):** Scratch marks on the inside of the lid. Eleanor was buried alive — or locked in and left to die.
 - ◆ **DC 13 Investigation (the letter on the altar):** The blood-stained letter is a love letter from Eleanor to Edmund, written the night before their wedding. The blood is Edmund’s — he was holding it when he died.
 - ◆ **DC 14 Investigation (Edmund’s body):** No visible cause of death. No wounds, no poison. He died of fright — or his heart stopped.
 - ◆ **DC 12 Religion or Medicine:** The wedding ring on Edmund’s finger matches the locket on the altar. Eleanor has "claimed" him — forcing him to wear the ring in death that he used to murder her in life.

THE CRYPT AWAKENING

The dead rise — the party must survive

DANGER ●●●●●



The crypt awakens — Eleanor rises from her tomb as the party confronts the horror beneath the church.

THE TRIGGER

Eleanor manifests when any of the following occur:

- ◆ A living creature touches Eleanor's sarcophagus
- ◆ A living creature reads the blood-stained letter aloud
- ◆ The organ is destroyed
- ◆ Midnight strikes (if the party is still in the crypt)
- ◆ A living creature attempts to remove the wedding ring from Edmund's body

THE BATTLE

"The green light flares blindingly bright. The sarcophagi explode outward — stone lids crashing to the floor. Skeletal hands claw their way up from the tombs. And from the central sarcophagus, a figure rises — a woman in a decayed wedding dress, her veil torn, her eyes burning with cold blue fire. She opens her mouth and the sound that comes out is not a scream — it's a wedding vow, spoken in a dead woman's voice: 'I do.'"

Enemies: 1× Eleanor Ashworth (Revenant, see P9 stats) + 4× Skeletons (use Skeleton stat block). The skeletons rise from the other sarcophagi and attack the nearest living creatures.

Terrain: The crypt is a 40×30 ft. room. Sarcophagi provide half cover (AC +2). The altar in the center is 5 ft. square and elevated 1 ft. The organ is against the far wall (AC 10, 15 HP).

Dynamic Element: The organ continues to play, creating supernatural interference. At the start of each round, roll a d6: on a 1–2, all creatures in the crypt must make a **DC 12 WIS save** or be frightened of Eleanor until the start of their next turn.

RESOLVING THE ENCOUNTER

Eleanor can be defeated by reducing her to 0 HP (she reforms in 24 hours unless the curse is broken). To permanently lay her to rest, the party must:

- ◆ **Option A — The Ring:** Remove the wedding ring from Edmund's body and place it in Eleanor's sarcophagus. Eleanor's spirit finds peace. She thanks the party with a whisper: "Thank you. I can rest now."
- ◆ **Option B — The Truth:** Read the blood-stained letter aloud at Eleanor's grave, proclaiming Edmund's guilt publicly. Eleanor's rage subsides. She fades, whispering: "He will answer for what he did. In this world or the next."
- ◆ **Option C — Destroy the Body:** Destroy Eleanor's remains in the sarcophagus (AC 12, 20 HP, immune to necrotic/poison). Her spirit is released but angry — she becomes a free-roaming haunt. *Not recommended.*

TREASURE & REWARDS

What the party gains from their investigation

TREASURE

SILVER HOLY SYMBOL OF ST. AGATHA

Given by Father Benedict. Grants +1 to saving throws against undead while held. (Wondrous item, uncommon)

ELEANOR'S LOCKET

Found on the altar in the crypt. A silver locket containing a miniature portrait of Eleanor. While worn, the bearer has advantage on saves against being frightened by undead. (Wondrous item, uncommon, requires attunement)

ASHWORTH FAMILY RING

The wedding ring from Edmund's body. A gold band set with a small ruby. Worth 50gp. If placed in Eleanor's sarcophagus, it lays her spirit to rest (see P11).

LADY CORDELIA'S GRATITUDE

If the party lays Eleanor to rest and reveals the truth, Cordelia rewards them with **100gp** from the Ashworth estate and a **Potion of Greater Healing**.

EXPERIENCE POINTS

Recommended XP awards (for milestone leveling, this adventure should advance characters to level 5 if they are level 3, or serve as a side quest for level 5 characters):

- Investigating the crypt and discovering the truth: **250 XP**
- Defeating or laying Eleanor to rest: **500 XP**
- Defeating the skeletal guardians: **200 XP**
- Resolving the mystery without violence (social solution): **100 XP** bonus

THE BLOOD-STAINED LETTER (HANDOUT)

The letter found in Lord Edmund's study and on the crypt altar. Show or give this handout to players when they discover it.



Handout: The Blood-Stained Letter — Found in Lord Edmund's study and on the crypt altar. The letter reads: "My dearest Edmund, Tomorrow I become your wife and the happiest woman alive. I have no family left, no fortune but my love. You are my whole world. Forever yours, Eleanor."

THE TWIST & EPILOGUE

The truth comes to light

THE TWIST

If the party investigates thoroughly, they discover the full truth:

"The blood-stained letter tells only half the story. Lord Edmund Ashworth married Eleanor for her family's land — the fertile fields east of Ashwick that bordered his estate. On their wedding night, rather than consummate the marriage, Edmund led Eleanor to the crypt beneath the church. He locked her inside and left her to die. She scratched at the stone lid until her fingers bled. She died alone in the dark, wearing her wedding dress, clutching the love letter she'd written him that morning."

Eleanor's death gave Edmund access to her lands through a clause in the marriage contract. He told the village she "died of a sudden illness" and buried her quietly. For twenty years, the secret stayed buried — until Eleanor's rage grew strong enough to wake her from the grave.

EPILOGUE

With Eleanor laid to rest, the supernatural events in Ashwick cease. The bells fall silent. The fog lifts. The village begins to heal.

Lady Cordelia inherits Ashworth Hall and the estate. If the party revealed the truth, she publicly acknowledges her father's crime and donates the Ashworth lands east of the village to the families who work them. She becomes a fair and beloved leader.

Father Benedict performs a proper funeral for Eleanor, with the whole village in attendance. He finally has peace.

Silas tends Eleanor's grave daily, planting white roses. He dies peacefully two years later and is buried beside the graveyard he loved.

"The village of Ashwick remembers. They remember Eleanor Ashworth — not as a ghost, but as a woman wronged. And every year, on the anniversary of her death, they leave a white rose on her grave. The requiem is over. The dead can rest."

DM NOTE

Sequel Hook: If you want to continue the campaign, Eleanor's locket contains a clue — inside the portrait is a tiny map showing a location in the nearby Dreadwood forest. This could lead to a larger adventure involving the Ashworth family's darker secrets, or a new threat drawn by the supernatural energy Eleanor's death released.

DM NOTES & SCALING

Tips for running the adventure

tone & atmosphere

This adventure is **gothic horror** — emphasis on atmosphere, dread, and tragedy rather than pure combat. The horror comes from the revelation of what happened to Eleanor, not from jump scares. Play up the sadness of the story. Eleanor is not evil — she's a victim seeking justice.

Music suggestions: Pipe organ ambient, funeral dirges, creaking doors, distant bells. Silence is also effective — long pauses build tension.

Lighting: If playing in person, dim the lights. Use candles. If playing online, consider sharing a dark, atmospheric background image during crypt scenes.

scaling the adventure

level	adjustment
1–2	Reduce Eleanor to a Specter (HP 27). Remove the skeletal guardians. Reduce crypt DCs by 2.
3–5	Use as written. This is the intended level range.
6–8	Increase Eleanor's HP to 90. Add 2 more Skeletons. Increase crypt DCs by 2. Eleanor gains Legendary Resistance (1/day).
9–12	Eleanor is a full Revenant with 120 HP. Add 4 Skeletons and 1 Wight. The crypt has additional traps (DC 14 Perception to spot, 2d10 necrotic damage).

optional encounters

- ◆ **The Dreadwood:** If the party investigates the forest, they find ancient standing stones and evidence of old rituals. A **Will-o'-Wisp** lures them deeper. This can be a side quest or sequel hook.
- ◆ **The Rival Investigators:** Another group of adventurers is also investigating Ashwick's hauntings. They can be allies or competitors depending on how the party interacts with them.
- ◆ **Cordelia's Secret:** If the party is hostile to Cordelia, she reveals she's been trying to atone for her father's sin. This can turn a potential enemy into a tragic ally.

adventure summary

Act 1 — Arrival & Investigation: The party arrives at Ashwick for Lord Edmund's funeral. They explore the village, meet the NPCs, and hear rumors about Eleanor. The wake at Ashworth Hall provides social encounter opportunities. Act 3 — Resolution: The party must defeat or lay Eleanor to rest. The ring or the letter can resolve the curse. The truth about Edmund's crime comes to light.	Act 2 — The Crypt: The party investigates the crypt beneath the church. They discover the truth about Eleanor's death. The dead rise. Eleanor manifests as a Revenant. Epilogue: Ashwick heals. Cordelia inherits. Eleanor rests. The requiem is over.
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APPENDIX: RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Optional encounters for exploration and atmosphere

VILLAGE ENCOUNTERS (ROLL D8)

D8	ENCOUNTER
1	Mourning Villager: A woman weeps by the fountain. She tells the party Lord Edmund was "a good man" but seems uncertain. DC 13 Insight: She's hiding something — she saw Edmund enter the crypt the night he died.
2	Raven Swarm: A flock of ravens circles the church spire, cawing loudly. DC 12 Nature check: Ravens gathering like this is an omen of death in local folklore.
3	Drunken Pallbearer: One of the funeral pallbearers is drunk at The Drowned Crow. He mumbles about "the woman in white" and "the scratching in the walls."
4	Traveling Merchant: A merchant arrived for the funeral and is stuck in the village. He sells basic supplies (50% markup due to demand) and shares rumors from other villages about "strange lights in the Dreadwood."
5	Child's Drawing: A child has drawn a picture of "the lady in white" standing by the graveyard. The drawing is surprisingly accurate — it shows Eleanor's wedding dress and the locket.
6	Church Bell: The church bell rings once at random during the day. No one is in the bell tower. DC 14 Investigation: The bell rope is frayed — it was recently used.
7	Gravedigger's Discovery: Silas has found something in the graveyard — a second grave, unmarked, near the mausoleum. It's empty. The earth is disturbed from below.
8	Peaceful Moment: The party finds a quiet spot overlooking the village. For a moment, the fog lifts and Ashwick looks beautiful — green fields, warm lights, children playing. Then the fog rolls back in.

CRYPT ENCOUNTERS (IF THE PARTY EXPLORES BEFORE MIDNIGHT)

D6	ENCOUNTER
1	Cold Spot: The temperature drops 20°F in one corner of the crypt. DC 13 Arcana: This is where Eleanor died. Her residual pain lingers.
2	Whispers: Faint whispering from inside a sealed sarcophagus. DC 12 Perception: It's not words — it's scratching. Something is trying to get out.
3	The Organ Plays: The pipe organ plays a single chord — a minor key, mournful and wrong. DC 14 Religion: This is a funeral dirge, but in a key associated with curses.
4	Blood on the Walls: Fresh blood drips from the ceiling near Eleanor's sarcophagus. It spells out a single word: "PROMISE."
5	Ghostly Apparition: A translucent figure — Eleanor as she was in life, beautiful and smiling — appears briefly near the altar. She reaches out, then fades. DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) to communicate: She mouths the word "ring."
6	The Door Locks: The crypt door slams shut and locks (DC 16 Strength to force, or DC 14 Thieves' Tools). The party has 10 minutes before Eleanor manifests.



"The village of Ashwick remembers. They remember Eleanor Ashworth — not as a ghost, but as a woman"